

Diffusion of Language

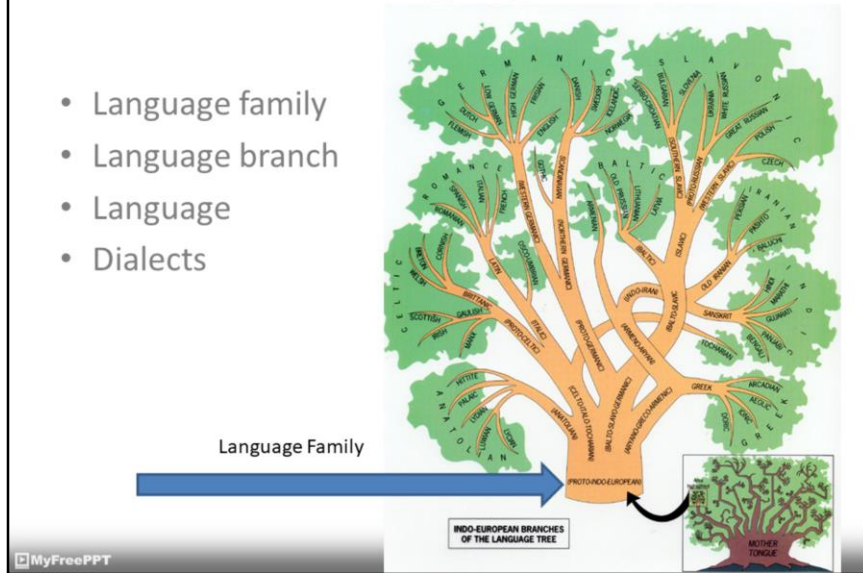


RRHS APHG
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The Language Tree

- Language family
- Language branch
- Language
- Dialects

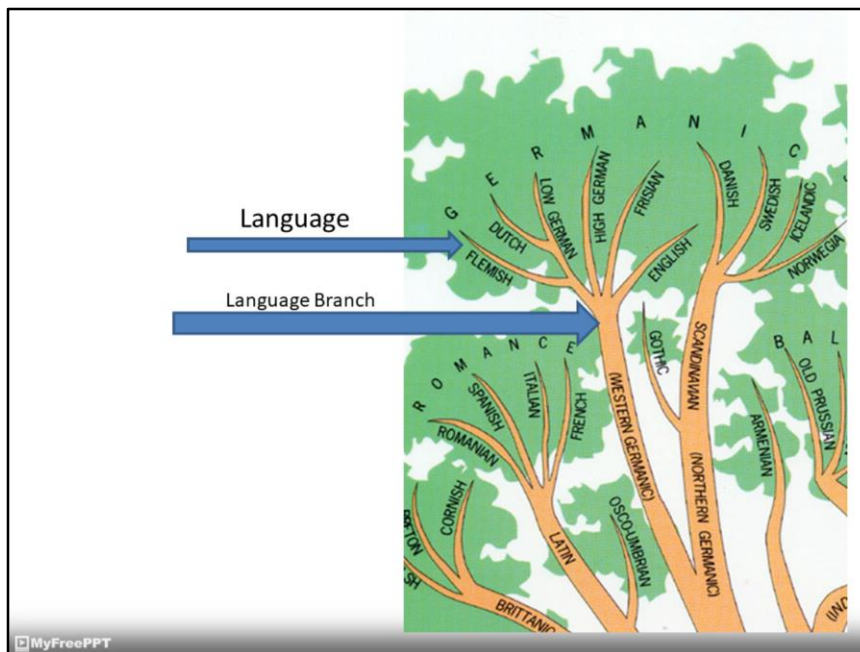


Language is ever-evolving. Even within a few generations, syntax (the arrangement of words in a sentence), pronunciations and spelling (diction), and even the meanings of words can change. New words are introduced, while others become archaic (no longer in every-day use). Languages evolve through a complex combination of *divergence* (separation from other groups speaking the same language), *convergence* (interacting with new groups and adopting some of their language), and *extinction* (where a language dies out).

Modern languages can be traced back to prehistoric times, but it becomes very difficult to trace them beyond written records. Instead, linguist (people who study language) look for clues as to how languages are related to each other, and where they may have broken off from other languages. They are traced backwards from modern times through history instead of the other way around. As these links between languages are found and traced further and further back, they are grouped into “language branches” which are related to other language branches within the same language family. The **language family tree** is an illustration of how varying religions are related.

Page 155 of your book shows the “IndoEuropean Language Family” portion of the

“language tree”. IndoEuropean languages are all related and can all be traced back to a common origin, which is thought to have its “Hearth” in Anatolia (modern day Turkey). However, this language family pre-dates this hearth and began in the nomadic tribes that roamed the earth. After the Neolithic Revolution (1st agricultural revolution when settlements/civilizations formed), languages became formalized and much more complex, and even developed a system of writing (and when writing began, that is when “history” began because everything before that time in that place is considered “pre-historic”).



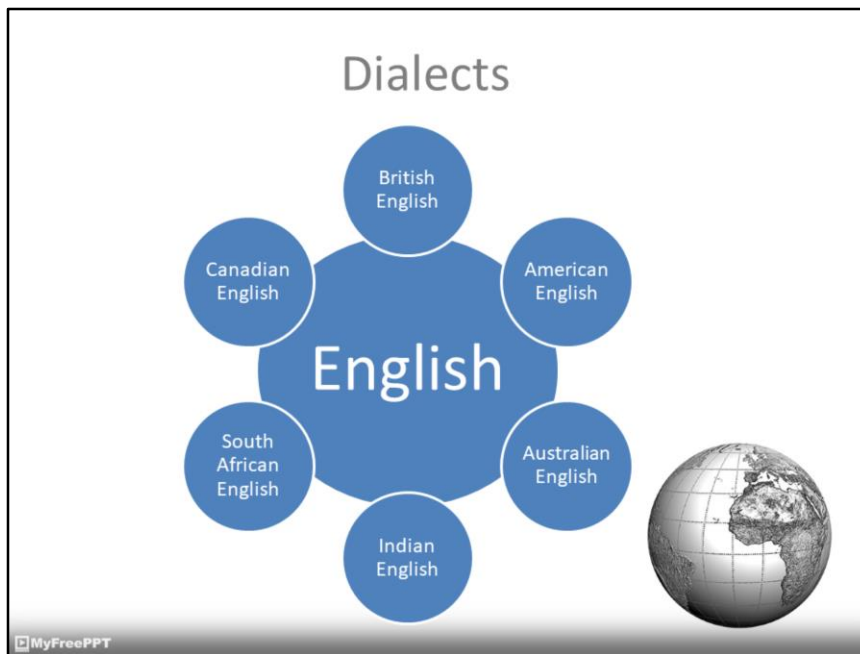
The image above is a “zoomed” in section of the illustration on the previous slide. It is centered around the Germanic “branch” of the IndoEuropean language family.

A language is the words, their pronunciation, and the methods of combining them used and understood by a community/society.

Language branches are a group of closely related languages. The arrow labeled “language branch” above is pointing to the “Western Germanic” language branch – this language branch includes languages such as Dutch, Flemish, German, English, and others. They are NOT **mutually intelligible**. In linguistics, **mutual intelligibility** is a relationship between languages in which speakers of different but related varieties can readily understand each other without prior familiarity or special effort.

The Romance Branch is another branch of closely-related languages, all based on Latin (the language of the Romans, hence “Romance”). Italian, French, Spanish, Portuguese, Romanian, and Romansch (one of the official languages of Switzerland) are all Latin-based Romance languages. Spanish, Portuguese, and Italian have enough in common that they are moderately mutually intelligible, particularly in written form. If you can speak and read any one of those three languages, you can typically

understand enough of a written passage of another in order to get an idea of what it says.



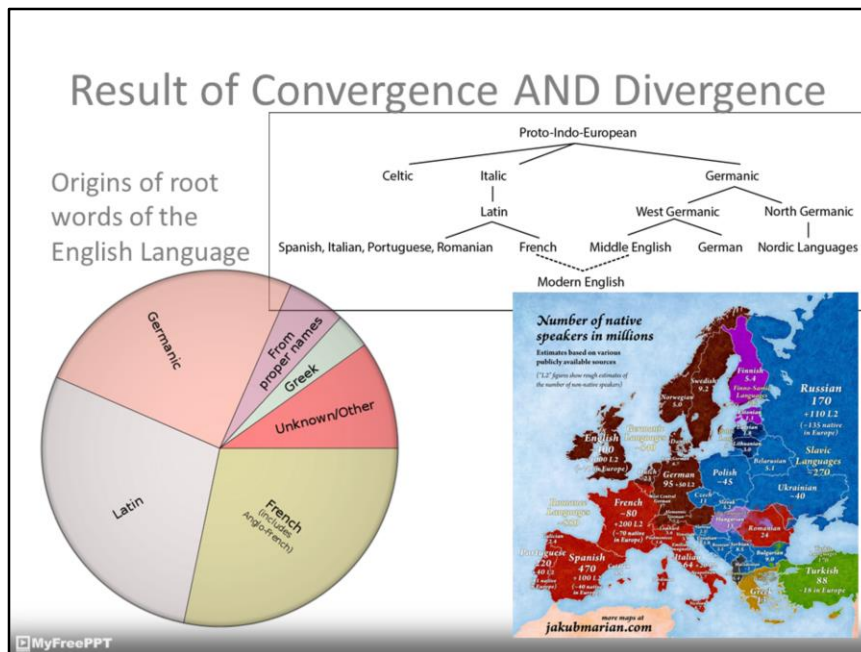
A dialect is a particular form of a language which is peculiar to a specific region or social group. Dialects have their own sets of diction and syntax, but are *almost* always mutually intelligible because they are the same language – the words, spellings, and idioms* may be different, but in general two people who speak different dialects of the same language should have no problem communicating with each other, though difficulty understanding the spoken language or misunderstandings (especially due to idiom use) can be an issue at times.

Dialects also pick up new words based on cultural convergence – for example, American English has many words that come from Native American languages, particularly for plants and animals. “*askútasquash*” is a native American word that was used to describe a plant native to the Americas that the British settlers had never seen before – the English speakers eventually shortened to word to “squash”. Meanwhile, a British English speaker may call it a courgette (a borrowed French word).

**an idiom is a group of words established by usage as having a meaning that cannot be deduced from the meanings of the individual words, such as “go on a wild goose chase” (pointless activity) or “break a leg” (wishing someone good luck). A common British idiom is “putting the cat with the pigeons”, which means to cause chaos or stir*

up trouble.

Vernacular dialects are specific to certain geographic areas – for example, the vernacular (perceptual/identity) regions of the United States have distinctive sounds and words within the American English dialect so much so that it is possible to tell from where in the U.S. a person is from just by listening to them speak – i.e., the South, the Midwest, Boston, Louisiana, etc. Vernacular dialects may also be referred to as **regional** dialects.



Why are the origins of language so confusing?

Language is tricky. As I mentioned earlier, English is part of the Germanic Branch of the IndoEuropean language family. It seems strange, then, that according to the chart above, only about one quarter of our words are of Germanic origin. How, then, is English Germanic and not Romance, since over *half* of our words are derived from Latin or French?

The answer can be explained with how languages form through BOTH cultural convergence AND cultural divergence. Western Europe is dominated by two language branches: The Romance and the Germanic. There is a distinctive cultural divide between the two, which have played out numerous times in many cultural conflicts over centuries. The French and Germans seem to innately be rivals. On the map above, the red areas are Romance-language speakers, and the brown areas are Germanic language speakers (the blue are Slavic branch languages, and the purple of Hungary, Finland, and parts of Russia is not an IndoEuropean language, but rather belong to the Uralic language family). You can clearly see a regional divide between the Romance languages speakers and the Germanic languages speakers.

Humans made their way onto the British Isles during the last Ice Age, which ended about 11,000 years ago. As the waters of the ocean rose and separated the British Isles from the European continent, cultural divergence occurred. Old English (the oldest known version of English) was almost entirely Germanic (created through cultural divergence and isolation from places where other Germanic languages are spoken).

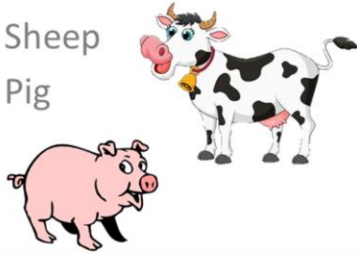
Then, the Romans spread their Empire throughout Europe, Southwest Asia, and North Africa, including reaching into the southernmost parts of Great Britain (the largest of the British Isles). Introduced their culture and religion onto the island and mingled with the occupants of Great Britain, cultural convergence occurred (Latin influence).

Next, in 1066, William the Conqueror of France invaded, bringing Norman culture with his armies. This began a long period of French control over England (the royal families of England and the higher classes spoke the language of the Normans (an Ethnic group from France) throughout the Middle Ages (aka, the Dark Ages or Medieval Europe – the period of time after the Roman Empire collapsed in the West until the Renaissance in the mid 15th century). England, during this time, was distinctively Tri-lingual. The commoners (peasants) spoke the more pure Germanic form of English. The nobility spoke a diluted version of Norman French, and the Clergy (Catholic religious leaders who had a major role in society) spoke Latin. The interactions of these three groups of people (cultural convergence) led to major influences from French and Latin being added into the English language. It's base, however, is still Germanic as its earliest known roots have been traced back to the Germanic branch of the IndoEuropean language family tree.

Examples of Word Origins in English

German origin

- Deer
- Chicken
- Cow
- Sheep
- Pig



French origin

- Venison
- Poultry
- Beef
- Mutton
- Pork



The reason the words for living animals and the animal meat we eat have different names in English can be traced back the Norman Invasion (French) of Great Britain.

When animals are alive, in the stable or on the farm, they kept their Old English names: deer, chicken, cow, pig, sheep, etc. because the people doing the grunt work of the farm were the peasants – who spoke the Germanic English.

Once the animals were processed and cooked, however, the words were derived from French (they are English versions of the French words) – Venison, Poutry (poulet), beef (boeuf), mutton (mouton), etc. As the royal and upper class members of society were the most likely to be able to feast on meat, the words represent a class divide among the Anglo-Saxons (English of German descent) and the French following the Norman Conquest.

Pidgins and Creoles

- Simplified mixture of multiple languages
 - Pidgins have no native speakers
 - Creoles begin as pidgins, but become the first language for that place
 - Haitian French is a first language for many in Haiti
 - Mix of native language of Hispaniola (the Island on which Haiti is located), French (colonizers), and African languages (slaves)



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Pidgins have been discussed before, but this is a reminder that Pidgins are the result of cultural convergence

Creoles begin as pidgins but become so engrained within a culture that it eventually becomes the Native language spoken by the group (the first language learned as an infant/child and the one primarily spoken in the home.

Tracing Diffusion of Language

- Backwards Construction
 - Sound shifts
 - Cognates
 - Toponyms



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Languages are traced through “Backward Construction” -tracing sounds and words back in an effort to reconstruct elements of a prior common language.

Soundshift

**You say lootenant, we say
leftenant... two nations
divided by a common language**

	ENGLISH	AMERICAN
Advertisement	<i>Advertissment</i>	<i>Advertizement</i>
Lieutenant	<i>Leftenant</i>	<i>Lootenant</i>
Patriot	<i>Patriot</i>	<i>Paytriot</i>
Schedule	<i>Shedule</i>	<i>Skedule</i>
Premiere	<i>Premialr</i>	<i>Premir</i>
Monarch	<i>Monak</i>	<i>Monark</i>
Era	<i>Eera</i>	<i>Error</i>
Bouquet	<i>Bookay</i>	<i>Bokay</i>
Neither	<i>Nyther</i>	<i>Neether</i>
Glacier	<i>Glassiar</i>	<i>Glaysiar</i>
Zebra	<i>Zehbra</i>	<i>Zeebra</i>
Semi	<i>Semee</i>	<i>Semai</i>
Buoy	<i>Boy</i>	<i>Bui</i>
Nuclear	<i>Newclear</i>	<i>Nukilar</i>
Garage	<i>Garaj</i>	<i>Garidj</i>
The letter Z	<i>Zed</i>	<i>Zee</i>
Iraq	<i>Irak</i>	<i>Eyerak</i>
Lasso	<i>Lasu</i>	<i>Laysoo</i>
Vase	<i>Varze</i>	<i>Vayze</i>
Research	<i>Risearch</i>	<i>Reesearch</i>



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A **sound shift** is the result of cultural divergence – it is a systematic change in the pronunciation of a set of speech sounds as a language evolves. For example, over time, the pronunciation of vowels within words may change, leading to the word sounding different in two geographic regions that speak the same language. For example, vowels in British English and American English sound different, which gives the two geographic regions their distinctive dialects.

The above comparison chart provides phonetic pronunciations of a selection of English words in British Standard English (British English) and American Standard English (American English).

Cognates

- Roots of words have common origin
- Example: Milk

Latin	Italian	Spanish	French
lac	latte	leche	lait
German	Dutch	English	Russian
milch	melk	milk	moloko

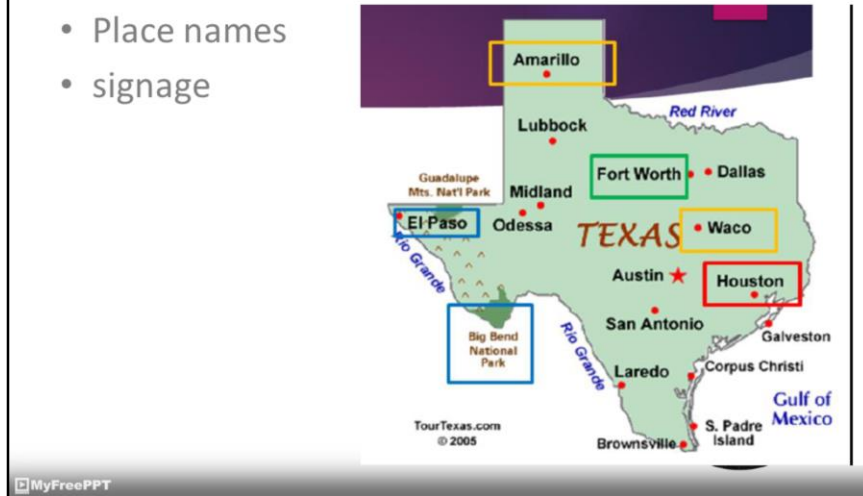


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A **cognate** means having the same linguistic derivation as another –that words in different languages are derived from the same original word or root. For example, the word “Star” in English is “starn” (Scottish English), “stern” (German), “Ster” (Dutch), “stjerne” (Norwegian and Danish). Compare to the Romance language cognates of star: “Astrel” (French), “Astro/stella” (Italian), “Estel” (Catalan Spanish), and “Estrella” (Spanish). Many times over the course of your educational pursuits, you will be informed that the “root word is....” as vocabulary terms are broken down for analysis (like we sometimes do in this class, but even more so in English).

Toponyms

- Place names
- signage



Toponyms are placenames. Linguists use place names to trace the occupancy of different regions across space to track the spread of a language. For example, Louisiana's capital is Baton Rouge – which means “Red Stick” in French. Because it is a French toponym, linguists are able to know French speakers once occupied that space. In the United States, also, are many Native American place names that represent the sequent occupancy of Native tribes on the continent (i.e., Sioux Falls, Idaho, etc.) and many Spanish language toponyms in the South and West (areas that were occupied by Spanish settlers, such as Los Angeles).

Toponyms also reflect the history of a place by honoring important persons and events in the place's history – i.e., multiple cities names “Washington” plus a U.S. state, many cities having a street named after “Martin Luther King, Jr.”, or naming them after important battles or other events. Toponyms reflect the physical landscape by taking on the names of distinctive physical features, such as “Round Rock”, “Baton Rouge”, etc.

Texas examples:

El Paso (shortened of El Paso del Norte – the North Path) is both Spanish and named for a geographic feature – the mountain pass in the northern portion of the Sierra

Madre Occidental Mountain range that runs through Northern Mexico.

Big Bend National Park – named for the “bend” in the Rio Grande (Big River).

Waco is named for the “Hueco” (Native American tribe) that occupied the area about 90 miles north of us.

Houston is named to honor Sam Houston, person of Historical importance in Texas

Amarillo means “yellow” in Spanish

Texas comes from “*taysha*”, which means “friends” in the Caddo Native tribe – the early settlers along the El Camino Real (historic road along connecting Spanish missions and settlements) pronounced this word, “Tejas” and from that, Texas was named.

Fort Worth was named after a military outpost in the “frontier” of Texas that no longer exists.

Signage is an artifact of the place’s culture(s). For example, in a place with signs in only one language (monolingual), you can assume the vast majority of people in that place speak (and can read) that language. If signs are **multilingual** (more than one language), you can assume that there are either multiple linguistic groups present in that place OR a lot of visitors come through who speak different languages from the one spoken in that place.

Diffusion of language families

- Language hearths
 - Two theories of diffusion
 - Conquest Theory
 - Renfrew Hypothesis



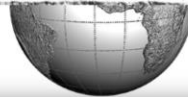
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Languages are more difficult to trace to specific hearths because they are much older than the earliest civilizations (began in the nomadic tribes, and each tribe had their own form of communication). These pre-historic languages form the “roots” of the language tree from which modern languages formed.

Linguist work to trace languages back to their earliest days through a process called

Conquest Theory

- Theory of spread of IndoEuropean languages
 - Spread via soldiers on horseback
 - Spread from Hearth (Anatolia) westward into Europe.



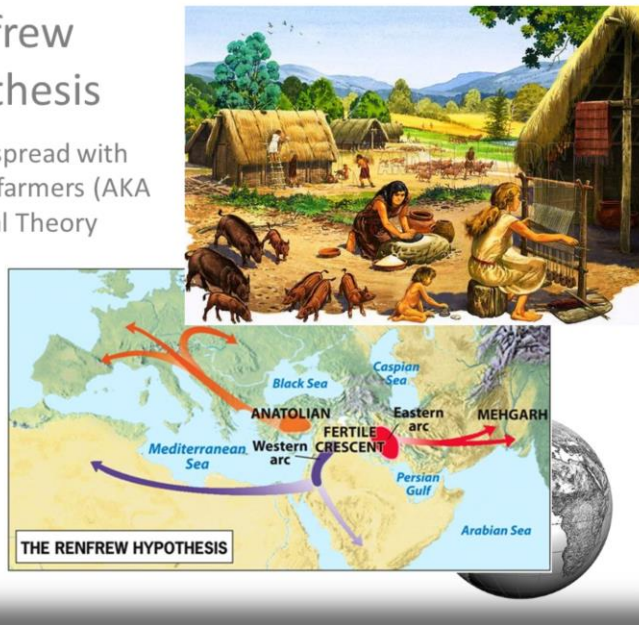
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The **Conquest Theory** is when a person or a group of people take control of an area and make everyone in that area follow their rules and beliefs.

The **Conquest Theory of Language Dispersal** posits that the IndoEuropean languages spread from it's theorized hearth in Anatolia (modern day Turkey) westward into Europe via soldiers on horseback. As the soldiers took over each area, they would force the conquered peoples to take on the new language, and their native languages would eventually die out (become extinct).

Renfrew Hypothesis

- Language spread with sedentary farmers (AKA Agricultural Theory)



The **Renfrew Hypothesis** is the theory of language dispersal in which the IndoEuropean languages spread out of their theorized hearth (still Anatolia) into Europe and South/Westward into Asia with the outward movement of sedentary farmers from the Fertile Crescent (the earliest agricultural hearth).

Barriers to Diffusion of Language

- Cultural
 - Greeks resisted Turkish rule and maintained their own language
 - The Basques took refuge in an isolated mountain
- Physical
 - Topography (mountainous regions)
 - Landcover (dense forests)
 - Oceans



As the farmers or soldiers spread their languages, they intermingled with nonfarming tribes, most of which were absorbed into the farming societies or conquered by the soldiers. A few societies held out, however, and these groups' languages did not become extinct until the period of the Roman Empire (2000 years ago). One group's language still exists today – **Basque**, spoken by an isolated group in the mountain range between Spain and France, is a **language isolate** – it is unrelated to any other known language therefore is a language family all on its own.

The map above shows the location of the Basque in a remote/isolated mountainous area on the border between France and Spain.

Modern-day distribution of Language

- Migration and legacy of colonialism
 - Relocation and hierarchical diffusion
 - Contagious diffusion through business and trade
 - The printing press
- Contemporary Diffusion
 - Availability of language-learning software and learning 2nd languages in school (hierarchical)
 - TV/Media (hierarchical)
 - Internet (mixture of contagious and hierarchical)



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You've read about the spread of culture (particularly language and religion) through colonization and imperialism, as well as the modern-day vectors of diffusion, TV, movies, radio, and the internet.

The first major technological innovation that led sped up the diffusion of language (and religion and other ideas) was Gutenberg's printing press. Prior to the printing press, texts had to be hand-copied, so they were often reserved to the religious and government leaders of the times (the elite members of society). With the advent of the printing press, knowledge and information could be printed into the local language and shared around the world, which led to the diffusion of language.

Impact of Language in Culture

- Standard language
- Official languages
- Vernacular (slang)



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A **standard language** is one that has been codified for standard grammar, spelling, and usage. – It has been formalized to have recognized “rules”. Standard languages are also the language employed by a population for public communications.

An **official language** is a language given a special legal status in a particular country, state, or other jurisdiction. Typically a country's official language(s) refers to the language(s) used in government.

A note here – the United States **does not** have an official language. In fact, there have been historic treaties and laws passed that varying languages will be given equal treatment. For example, when the U.S. acquired the northern half of Mexico’s territory following the Mexican-American War of 1848, the treaty that ended that war, *The Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo*, stipulated that the existing Spanish-speaking population would be able to continue using their native language and that Spanish would be treated as an equal language in government. Instead, American Standard English (the formalized dialect of English with established rules) is the **standard** (commonly used for official communications) language of the U.S.

A **Vernacular language** is also known as regional slang – it is the speech variety used in everyday life by the general population in a geographical or social territory

Centripetal/Centrifugal forces

- Forces that unify
 - Official language
 - Revived language
- Forces that divide
 - Linguistic Conflicts
 - Quebec (Canada)
 - Flanders and Wallonia (Belgium)



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Language is one of biggest components of culture that can unite or divide people within a country.

Forces that unify a group are known as “centripetal” and forces that divide are “centrifugal”

Centripetal forces

- Monolingual countries
- Official language(s)
- Revived (extinct) languages
- Liturgical languages



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If everyone in the same country speaks the same language, there is a sense of unity. We call these countries “monolingual” (mono=one, lingual=language). People within groups feel a sense of belonging if they speak the common language of the group. Those people that do not speak the language may feel like outsiders, and are seen as “different” by members of the group.

One way that governments work to create a sense of unity within is to set an “official” language – as mentioned earlier, this is a language with a special legal status and the language that the government does business in. If there are multiple ethnic groups within a country and they all speak different languages, the government may work to make sure all groups feel included by identifying each of the languages as an “official” language. For example, Switzerland is home to four different language groups, and as such, has four official languages – French, German, Italian, and Romansch.

Another way countries work to create unity is by reviving **extinct languages** – historic languages of the place that no longer have native speakers. For example, Hebrew was once an extinct language, but with the creation of Israel in 1948, Hebrew was identified as an Official language. Since the people were coming from many places

around the world and needed a common language (lingua franca), it made sense to use Hebrew since it is the *liturgical language* of the Jewish faith.

A **Liturgical language** is the official language of a religion. For example, to read the Torah, the holy book of Judaism, Jewish youth must learn Hebrew as they learn about their religion. Other languages have liturgical languages as well – Latin (also considered an extinct language as there are not thought to be any native speakers – it is a second language to those who speak it) is the liturgical language of Catholicism (a branch of Christianity), and Arabic is the liturgical language of Islam. These languages often diffuse in conjunction with the religions as they are needed to understand their teachings and read their sacred texts.

Centrifugal forces

- Multilingual countries
- Regional divisions



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Multilingualism by itself is NOT a centrifugal force. It becomes a one, however, when there are other circumstances in place that add to the divide between groups.

Language and religion are the two biggest contributing elements of culture that make up a person's identity and ethnicity. If there is inherent inequity between groups, and especially if **regional divides** exist, there is often conflict.

You know enough about cultures by now to know that the concept of all humans being equal is a recent phenomenon. Ethnic groups generally have a desire to govern themselves, set their own social norms, and control their own land and resources. Inequality contributes to an "us vs. them" mentality, and over time resentment can build when one group has a privileged status or control over another. You also know that boundaries are often overlapping or contested – two groups may hold claim to the same territory. This can lead to fighting between the groups over that territory.

The next few slides will outline two of the more famous linguistic conflicts today: Quebec and Belgium.

Linguistic Conflicts: Quebec

- French speaking region of Canada



Who:

Group 1: the French speaking Quebecois of Quebec, Canada

Group 2: The English speaking Canadians of the rest of Canada

What

Historically, Quebec was a French colony, and most of eastern Canada was a British colony. British claims spread across the continent throughout the 1800s-1900s. Canada was declared a self-governing entity within the British Empire in the 1860s, but did not fully gain independence until 1982. Since this time, the Quebecois have been pushing for greater autonomy (self-rule) or independence, largely on linguistic, religious (Quebec is Catholic, while the rest of Canada is predominantly Protestant, a separate branch of Christianity), and economic grounds.

Why it matters – while mostly peaceful, this conflict flairs up at times in protests, separatist movements, and votes for independence. The Quebecois consider English-speaking Canadians and Americans to have “pushy” cultures and have taken measures to pass protective laws in an order to preserve the French culture of the province. For example, French must be more prominent on business signs, schools must teach in French, and the French language of the Quebecois is actually more

resistant to English-word encroachment than even in France. For example, it is common in France to refer to Saturday and Sunday as “le week-end”, but in Quebec, it is frowned upon to use the borrowed English words, and one is expected to say “la fin de semaine”. Above is the familiar hexagonal traffic sign that is familiar to us – except that it says “Arrêt” instead of the English word “STOP”.

Migration in Quebec Quebec is home to immigrants from all over the world – the government recognizes the importance of migration into the province to offset historically low birthrates. To preserve the culture, however, migrants are expected to take French language classes.



Who:

Group 1: Flemish (who speak Flemish – a dialect of Dutch) in Flanders – $\frac{3}{4}$ of the population of Belgium. Flanders is the northern half of Belgium

Group 2: French speakers in Wallonia – $\frac{1}{3}$ of the population. Brussels, the capital of Belgium, is located in Flanders, but has a majority of French speakers.

What: Belgium is located on the boundary between the Germanic ethnicities of Europe and the French ethnicities of Europe – a divide that through history has caused significant rivalries. Brussels is officially bilingual – both Flemish and French are official languages. There are economic differences between French-Wallonia and Flemish-Flanders. Historically, Wallonia was part of the “Economic Core” of Europe – meaning it was part of the industrial heartland and wealthy compared to historically rural and agricultural Flanders (this divide is very similar to the divide between the Industrial North and Agricultural South of pre-civil war U.S.). However, Belgium is a highly economically developed country, and as such is also highly dependent on machinery – factories employ only a small percent of the population today, which means Wallonia is struggling economically as their economy was previously dependent on factories that have now moved to other countries. Flanders, in contrast, is experiencing economic prosperity as they have been able to capitalize on

the shift to service sector jobs and technology-focused industries.

What's the Issue? French speakers of Wallonia make up only 1/3 of the population, yet they have the majority share of government power. They are also struggling economically, so they are supporting fiscal policies that force the more prosperous Flanders to economically support economically stagnant Wallonia. The Flemish want more control over their own economics and resources.

Why does this conflict matter?

In 2007, the country was so divided that it shut down the government for over 6 months – they were not able to form a majority government within the parliamentary system. If the country were to split into two, it would negate hundred of trade agreements and treaties that have been negotiated over the past few decades. This would be a diplomatic nightmare for the international community. Other countries could refuse to recognize the legality of a partitioned Belgium because to do so might encourage separatist movements within their own countries.